

Moonsea Rising - 20231119

When Are We?

The party gathers the cultists, and looks through their belongs. Taevyn nimbly pockets the ring before the others can examine it, to pointed looks from Lennox and Beitris. Interestingly, this cultist also have several maps on him, but they look... odd. Lirael recognizes almost immediately that Hillsfar's map is only the old city, and the Melvaunt map is similarly out of date. The third, "Merrat", shows a county that looks much more sparse than they have encountered, with names that are well out of date. There are numerous things missing, references to slavery, and myriad other anachronisms.

Taevyn and Lennox are deeply interested in the door behind the rune. Beitris and Lirael think fouling the rune should work, but it is etched into stone. Grimly, the two men set to work on the block with some of the torture implements, carefully working from the side to destabilize the rune's underpinings. They eventually wear enough of the material away, and Taevyn strides -- confidently or foolishly -- across the broken rune, assuming that's sufficient. He turns out to be correct, and opening the door they find another similar hallway to the one they've left. To the north, there are several more ambulatory mushrooms, as well as the bend of the waterway. He creeps further along and finds a side branch with more fungus and another door. Lennox joins him, and the mushrooms turn towards the two of them and begin advancing.

One move up and strikes Lennox, spraying him with spores, and whacking him with its tentacle. Lirael strides forward and uses tanglefoot to slow it down. Taevyn flips past it, lashing out with his rapier and cutting huge swaths of its fiber away. Lennox knocks it down, chopping away at it, as he sways slightly from the spore infection. Harken cuts it down with his telekinetic abilities, and Beitris spears the one next to it with a divine lance. The fungi continue to strike at Lennox.

Lirael focuses her magic, and a her arm turns into a gouging claw, stretching and lengthening to impossible dimensions, slashing at the mushroom by Taevyn, over 20' down the hallway. Taevyn flips past it, spearing it with his rapier, and shredding it on his follow-through. Harken and Beitris target the next mushroom, bringing it down with their powers.

The last mushroom continues to strike at Lennox, hitting him once. Lirael moves across the opening from it, firing a ray of frost, which rips into it as Taevyn whips by it, chopping it cleanly in thirds.

Taevyn and Lennox move to the door, opening and quickly slamming it. Lirael prepares a ghost sound to hopefully confuse their tremor sense behind them. Lennox opens the door, and two of the fungi immediately attack him. He slashes with his axe, knocking one down, and catching the one next to it on his two slashes, and destroying the one he knocks over. Lirael releases the ghost sound, but the effect seems to be limited.

Taevyn whirls about, desperately trying to look cool before slashing out at the mushrooms. After a couple of tries, he finds his groove and skewers the nearest one badly. Beitris and Lirael finish it

off with light and frost respectively. Back in the room, one of the mushrooms confusedly moves to attack where the ghost sound is coming from.

Lennox and Harken manage to put down the last one that isn't distracted. The group moves to quickly dispatch it before it can move to attack. They find three beds with dead cultists, though the corpses appear to be hundreds of years old. The party decides to camp out in this room, though Lirael is confused as to why there'd be both living cultists and long-dead ones in the same complex, as well as a variety of dangerous creatures.

Still Not Dead Yet

The party decamps after everyone is rested. Exiting the room, they don't find anything lying in wait for them, despite Lirael's misgivings. Moving to the north, Taevyn sees more cultists around the corner. As they debate their next course of action, more fungi rise up to attack them. Low chanting starts around the corner. Lirael tanglefoots the nearest mushroom, backing away from the corridor intersection. Taevyn fires two shots with his crossbow at the mushrooms, following Lirael backwards.

Fighting and backing up, the party hears a klaxon sounds down the corridor and the chanting redoubles. The mushrooms continue advancing, as the strange chanting increases in volume and fervor. A small stone bounces around the corner. Taevyn and Lennox dive for cover, but Beitris is caught in a massive blast of source, as are the two mushrooms. Lirael and Taevyn kill the struggling mushrooms, while maintaining their angle on the corridor.

Beitris prays, and a circular bubble of light forms around her and most of the party. One of the cultist steps up and fires a crossbow at Lennox, hitting him. He calls to the others, "what are you doing? Attack him!" Another cultist steps up and slashes him with a greasy kukri. The third cultist, wearing silver-trimmed robes of high quality, casts a spell attacking Lennox's mind. The dome of light crackles and pulses, and Lennox seems unaffected. Lirael shouts at the caster, "your god is dead, you fool! Lay down your arms!" The priest merely laughs. She launches a bolt of searing fire at the cultist in front of Lennox, burning the man extravagantly.

Beitris summons her spiritual mace, swinging at the leader. One of the cultists says to him, "they're going to interrupt the ceremony!" He laughs and tells the man, "it's too late." The cultist bows his head, and charges Harken, slashing him with his kukri. The priest sends black tendrils out to lash Lennox, Taevyn, and Beitris. Lennox rushes forward and smashes the leader with his axe. The cultist next to him moves to flank him, but cannot land a hit.

Darting forward, Lirael weaves between the combatants towards a opening behind the scrum. Muttering the words of her spell, she shifts and grows. Standing up and roaring, she turns into a tyrannosaurus, taking up half the hallway. Dancing forward, Taevyn spins and whirls, executing his dance moves. He stabs the caster, ripping his form through the man, and cutting him badly. Beitris strikes him with her spiritual weapon, and heals herself, cutting off the bleeding from the tentacle attack. The cultist between Liraelosaurus and Harken strikes at him, but misses. The leader reaches out and touches Lennox's forehead, and the big man fades and disappears. Liraelosaurus, thinking Lennox has been disintegrated. Lennox, however, simply sees the world in limed in bright purple light as the sounds fade around him.

Harken slashes at the cultist between him and Liraelosaurus with his rapier, then smashes out with his telekenesis, but the cultist fends off the blows. In the fading world in which Lennox finds himself, he swings his axe at the priest. A perfect cut, but it slashes directly through the man as though he were not there. All he can hear is the sound of the chanting, which continually grows in volume. The cultist that was attacking Lennox turns on Taevyn. His first shot misses so badly that Taevyn tags him with a riposte. After missing a second time, he raises his hand and blows some kind of flakey skin dust at Taevyn, but the boy dances away. Liraelosaurus bites the priest twice, savaging the man, and swings her tail at him, but he manages to deflect that blow.

Taevyn spins and dances, stabbing the priest twice, the final blow passing through the man's throat as he falls to the ground. The cultist between Harken and Liraelosaurus turns tail and flees down the corridor towards the chanting. Harken steps towards the remaining cultist, running him through badly with his rapier. The cultist is bleeding heavily and off-balance after the blows, and he follows him companion fleeing down the hallway. Roaring, Liraelosaurus stomps after him, biting him as she passes, heading towards the source of the chanting. Taevyn sprints behind her, killing the cultist as he passes, and moves to flank the other cultist. He flees into the room the chanting is coming from.

As Harken and Beitris struggle to catch up with the party, the insubstantial shade of Lennox drifts into the room, where the light looks least purple. He sees an archway that leads into a room that looks normal and non-purple. A priest with a sacrificial dagger stands over a woman on an altar. A couple of cultists on the other side of the portal notice him, and point in his direction. Liraelosaurus follows, unbeknownst to her, and sees the arch glowing purple, the cultist on his knees before it summoning his healing fungus. She stamps through the portal, appearing in the scene Lennox saw. The cultists are shocked by her appearance, and the chanting falters. The high priest tells them, "no, you fools, we're too close!" As he raises his dagger over the sacrifice, she chomps him biting heavily into his flesh.

Taevyn comes along behind and asks the cultist where Lirael went. He says, "back." Taevyn cuts the man down and looks around bewildered. Harken and Beitris follow him. Harken asks where Lirael went, and Taevyn tells him he doesn't know. Taking the same guess Lirael did, he steps through the portal onto the scene of carnage she's attempting to create. He draws his dagger and throws it at the priest, though he manages to dodge.

Meanwhile, Lennox decides it's time to charge through the portal, which he does. Passing through the portal, he does appear to be back in reality, and his swing at the high priest glances off the man, but doesn't pass through him. Taevyn and Beitris, trailing behind follow the others through the portal.